

Using an Exported Magic Mask Matte for Targeted Color Grading in DaVinci Resolve 20 Studio

Introduction

Magic Mask is a powerful DaVinci Resolve tool for isolating a person or object, but it can be extremely GPU-intensive to use on every render. A practical workaround is to **export the Magic Mask result as a black-and-white matte clip** (white subject on black background) and use that matte inside your color node tree. This approach lets you apply precise color corrections to the masked subject without continuously re-tracking the Magic Mask, dramatically speeding up playback and final rendering ¹. In this guide, we'll walk through importing the external matte, integrating it into your Color page node structure, and adjusting your workflow for DaVinci Resolve 20's updates. We'll also cover **step-by-step instructions** and troubleshooting for common issues like matte misalignment, resolution mismatches, or alpha blending problems.

Why Replace Magic Mask with an External Matte

Performance and Reliability: Every time you use Magic Mask, Resolve's Neural Engine must track the subject, which can slow down your workflow. By using a pre-rendered matte file, you eliminate the need for AI tracking during grading – the matte is just a regular video file, so **no additional computation is needed** ¹. This means smoother playback and **faster exports**, since the mask is essentially “baked in” as footage. In fact, an external matte is a permanent file that *survives cache clears and project moves* and makes final renders **instant** with respect to masking overhead ¹.

Flexibility: Using an external matte within the color node tree gives you full control to adjust the subject and background separately, much like Magic Mask, but with more freedom to tweak grades. You can re-use the matte clip on other shots (if applicable), combine it with other qualifiers or Power Windows, and you never have to worry about the mask getting lost or needing to retrack if you duplicate the timeline or move the project. In professional workflows, exporting a luma matte for a roto or Magic Mask is a preferred method to “**permanently preserve your tracking work**” while keeping your grading flexible ².

Quality: Magic Mask in Resolve 20 (often called *Magic Mask 2*) is more accurate and faster than in Resolve 17–18 ³, but it still may struggle with complex edges or occlusions. By using the matte you've fine-tuned (perhaps even cleaned up in another application), you ensure the mask quality remains consistent. You can also refine the matte *inside* Resolve using key adjustments (blur, shrink/expand) without having to retrack anything.

Exporting the Magic Mask as a Matte Clip (Preparation)

Before diving into the Color page, you need a good matte clip exported from Magic Mask. Since the question assumes you already have this (a white-on-black video of the subject), we'll briefly outline how one can create it for completeness:

1. **Create the Magic Mask on your clip:** In the Color page, use the Magic Mask tool to isolate the person/object. Track it through the clip until the mask is complete.
2. **Pipe the mask to a visible output:** Connect the Magic Mask node's **blue output (mask)** to an RGB output so that you get a black-and-white image. The simplest method is to feed the Magic Mask's blue alpha output into the node tree's RGB output. For example, you can take a blank correction node and connect the Magic Mask blue output into that node's green (RGB) input ⁴. This node will now output a luma matte (white = masked subject, black = background). *(In Resolve 20, you may alternatively use a Color Generator node: pipe the Magic Mask's blue output to the Generator's blue input and enable an alpha output on the node, achieving the same result ⁴.)*
3. **Bypass other grades:** Disable any other color correction nodes so that the output is a clean black-and-white matte (no color changes baked in). You should see the subject as solid white on black background. If not, check the node's Key Output Gain (set it to 1.0 if the matte looks faint ⁵).
4. **Render the matte clip:** Back on the Edit page, select the clip and **Render in Place** (or use the Deliver page) to export the matte. Choose a high-quality format (e.g. ProRes 422 or DNxHR) to preserve detail. **Include color grading effects** so that the Magic Mask output (the B&W matte) is baked into the render ⁶ ⁷. Name this file clearly (e.g. `Scene5_SubjectMatte.mov`).
5. **Verify length, frame rate, and resolution:** For a foolproof workflow, export the matte at the **same resolution and frame rate** as the original clip, and for the exact duration needed. If possible, also maintain the same timecode reference. Matching these properties ensures the matte will line up perfectly in Resolve ⁸. In practice, if you render in place on the same source clip, Resolve will handle this (it often uses the source timecode for the new file). Having the matte **frame-accurate and in sync** with the original footage will save headaches later.

Tip: If you have handles or a longer source clip, consider generating the matte from the *full-length source* clip rather than a cut segment. Resolve can use timecode to auto-align an external matte to any trimmed timeline instance of that clip ⁹. In other words, if the matte file carries the source clip's original timecode, it will *"align automatically"* with that clip even in a different timeline with edits ⁹. This is very useful in one-person projects where you might cut the footage but still want the mask to attach correctly. However, if you only exported the trimmed section, don't worry – you can manually adjust the offset later (as discussed in Troubleshooting).

Importing the Matte Clip into Your Project

With the matte video ready, the next step is to bring it into DaVinci Resolve and **assign it as an external matte** for your footage. Resolve offers a dedicated mechanism for external mattes to ensure they sync up with the source clip:

1. **Import the matte into the Media Pool:** In the Media page or Edit page, import the matte video file (`.mov`, `.mp4`, etc.) as you would any footage. It will appear in your Media Pool.

2. **Link the matte to the source clip via Clip Attributes:** For the most foolproof alignment, use Resolve's **Clip Attributes matte linking**:
3. Right-click your **original clip** (the one that needs the mask) in the Media Pool and choose **"Clip Attributes..."**.
4. In the Clip Attributes dialog, go to the **Mattes** tab.
5. Click the **"Add Matte"** button (the + sign) and select the imported matte clip from the browser ¹⁰ . After clicking OK, you'll see that the source clip now has an external matte attached (in some Resolve versions, an icon or indicator may show up next to the clip in the pool ¹¹).
6. *Behind the scenes:* Resolve associates the matte file with your source clip using timecode and frame index. This means if both files share the same starting timecode or if the matte starts at 00:00:00:00 and your clip does too, the frames will correspond automatically. When you apply this matte in the Color page, it will appear in perfect sync.
7. **(Alternative) Add as matte directly from Media Pool:** If you prefer or if you have not linked via Clip Attributes, you can add the matte on the fly in the Color page. Open the **Media Pool panel** on the Color page (top right panel, usually where Gallery/ LUTs/ Media Pool can be toggled). Then **drag the matte clip** and drop it onto the node graph of your target clip's grade. The matte clip will be added into the node tree as an **External Matte node** ¹² (often a small node with a distinct icon). By default, Resolve will attempt to align it by timecode as well, but you may need to adjust settings if there's a mismatch (we'll address that shortly).
8. **Confirm the matte is recognized:** If added correctly, Resolve knows this clip is a matte. In newer versions, an external matte node will even carry the file's name as its label by default for easy identification ¹³ . If you added via Clip Attributes, the matte doesn't immediately appear in the node graph until you specifically use it (next step), but it's ready to be accessed from any node's Qualifier controls. Either way, you now have the matte available to use in your grade.

Applying the External Matte in the Color Node Tree

Now for the core part: **using the imported matte to constrain your color correction** just as Magic Mask would. There are two common ways to apply the matte in your node tree:

A. Masking a Correction Node with the External Matte (Serial Node Approach)

In this approach, you apply the matte to one or more correction nodes via the node's key input (or via the Qualifier panel). This is analogous to how you'd use Magic Mask on a node – the node's adjustments will only affect the masked areas.

Steps to use the matte on a node:

1. **Select your clip and prepare nodes:** Go to the Color page and select the clip you want to grade (the one linked to the matte). If you already have a node tree, decide where to insert the masked correction. Often, you might have a base grade node first, then a second node for the isolated correction. If starting fresh, one node will be used for the masked correction (and optionally another for the rest of the image or background).
2. **Add a serial node for the targeted correction:** Create a new Serial node (e.g. Node 2) which will be

dedicated to the subject/person isolation. For clarity, you can label this node "Subject Correction" or similar.

3. Apply the matte to that node:

- If you linked the matte via Clip Attributes, this is straightforward: select Node 2, then open the **Qualifier/Key** panel (the tab where you normally see eyedroppers for HSL keying, etc.). There will be a drop-down menu for **External Mattes/Mask** (it might say "Matte: <none>" initially). Click that drop-down and you should see an entry for **"Matte 1"** or the name of your matte file. Choose it ¹⁴. Node 2 will instantly be masked by the external matte – **any color adjustments on this node now affect only the white areas of the matte (the subject)** ¹⁴. The rest of the image (areas corresponding to black in the matte) will remain unchanged by this node.
- If you used the drag-and-drop method (External Matte node in the graph), then connect it manually: you should see a small external matte node (let's call it Node M). Drag a connection from Node M's output (usually a blue output dot) into the **blue triangle input** on your correction node (Node 2). This blue triangle is the node's key/mask input. Once connected, Node 2 will be constrained by that matte. (If Node M wasn't already assigned to the correct source, you might need to check its properties, but if the timecode matches it should line up.)
- **Verify the mask application:** It's good practice at this point to preview the mask. You can do this by toggling the highlight/external mask preview (the Magic Wand icon or press **Shift+H**). The viewer should show the matte overlay – you'll likely see the subject highlighted. If it appears inverted (i.e. the background is highlighted instead of the subject), simply invert the key: in the node's Key panel, click the **Invert** button for the external matte (**the drop-down will indicate if it's inverted**) ¹⁵. With white-on-black mattes, normally no inversion is needed (white = subject selected), but it's worth checking. Also ensure the mask lines up frame-accurately; scrub through a few frames to be sure the matte "sticks" to the subject correctly. If there's a timing offset, don't worry – see Troubleshooting for how to fix it.
- **Perform your color correction:** Now do the grading on Node 2 as needed – for example, adjust the exposure, color balance, or apply secondary grades to just the subject. Thanks to the matte, these changes only affect the masked area. The rest of the image remains untouched by Node 2. Essentially, you have replaced the Magic Mask with this static/tracked matte.
- **Add a background node (optional):** If you also want to grade the *inverse* (the background), you have two choices: (a) simply add another serial node *after* Node 2 and invert the matte on that node; or (b) use a parallel/layer mixer setup (covered in the next section). The simpler method is serial: e.g. Node 3 can be a "Background Correction" node. In Node 3's Key tab, select the same external matte **Matte 1** and then hit **Invert** ¹⁵. Now Node 3 will apply its adjustments only to the background (the previously black areas of the matte). Because Node 3 is after Node 2, it will see the image with Node 2's changes to the subject, but since Node 3 is inverted, it won't alter the subject further – it will only affect the surrounding areas. This serial approach effectively lets you grade subject and background separately in successive nodes. **For example:** Node 2 could brighten the person's face and Node 3 could cool down and darken the background, each confined by the matte mask.

Example node order: If we summarize, your node tree might look like:

- Node 1 – Primary grade (optional, or could be empty if not needed)
- Node 2 – Subject grade with external matte applied (person only)
- Node 3 – Background grade with **inverted** external matte (background only)
- (Then both feed into the output serially)

This yields a final image with both subject and background adjustments applied in their respective areas. All without using Magic Mask live – you’ve used the pre-rendered matte internally.

B. Using a Layer Mixer for Separate Subject and Background Branches

An alternate setup is to use a **Layer Mixer** node to composite two branches: one branch for the subject (using the matte) and one for the background. This approach can be more intuitive for some, as it mirrors a compositing workflow (subject layer over background layer), but functionally it achieves the same result as the serial method above.

Steps for a layer mixer setup:

1. In the Color node graph, start with your source node (Node 1). Create two new corrector nodes (Node 2 and Node 3) that will branch off in parallel. An easy way is to add a **Parallel Node** or **Layer Mixer**: for instance, right-click Node 1 and choose **Add Node → Add Layer Mixer**. Resolve will create a Layer Mixer and typically auto-connect Node 1 and a new Node 2 into it. You can then attach a Node 3 as the second branch if needed. The goal is to have two inputs into a Layer Mixer node.
2. Assign one node to the subject and one to the background. For clarity: let’s use Node 2 for the subject and Node 3 for the background. Connect both Node 2 and Node 3 into the Layer Mixer (the Layer Mixer has input slots; one is usually the *foreground/top* layer and the other the *background*). The Layer Mixer’s output goes to the final output.
3. **Apply the matte to Node 2 (subject):** On Node 2, go to the Key/Qualifier panel and select the external matte (Matte 1) as the mask (just as described earlier) ¹⁴. Do **not** invert it – this node should affect only the white (subject) area.
4. **Apply the inverted matte to Node 3 (background):** On Node 3, also select the same Matte 1, but **invert** it ¹⁵, so Node 3 will affect only the complementary area (background).
5. **Verify layering order:** In a Layer Mixer, the *top* input is normally treated as the foreground and uses its alpha (key) to composite over the lower layer. Ensure Node 2 (subject) is feeding into the top slot of the Layer Mixer and Node 3 feeds the bottom slot (you can swap inputs if needed by reconnecting wires). With Node 2 carrying the matte as an alpha, the Layer Mixer will composite the two: the subject node will cover the background node only where its matte allows (the white areas). The result is the same combined image: subject graded by Node 2, background graded by Node 3. If you solo-view the Layer Mixer output, it should look correct.
6. **Do the grading on each branch:** Now adjust Node 2 for the subject’s color corrections and Node 3 for the background’s corrections independently. For example, you might increase saturation on the subject in Node 2, while desaturating and blurring the background in Node 3. Because of the matte and the layer mixer, these changes won’t conflict – Node 2’s changes only appear over the subject area, and Node 3’s changes only show through on the background.

The layer mixer setup is effectively an explicit way of doing what the serial inverted nodes do. The final output is the same: a composited image with separate grades. Use whichever method you are more comfortable with – **Resolve’s color engine will yield identical results** if set up properly. The key is that the matte (and its inverse) cleanly splits the image for targeted adjustments. Many colorists find the serial method quicker for two layers, but a layer mixer can be useful if you plan to add *multiple* layers or effects (e.g., more than one element composited with different mattes).

Resolve 20 Workflow Notes (Compared to 17–18)

DaVinci Resolve 20 Studio introduced **Magic Mask 2.0**, which offers more accurate and faster masking within the Color page ³. However, the fundamental workflow of exporting and using an external matte remains consistent with earlier versions – with a few quality-of-life improvements:

- **Magic Mask improvements:** Resolve 20's Magic Mask can track using fewer strokes (even just “points” for objects) and handles occlusions better than in 17–18 ¹⁶. But it still does not carry over to the Fusion page and still requires re-tracking if you significantly change the clip or clear cache. Thus, the motivation to export a matte and avoid retracking is *still valid*. In fact, Blackmagic Design did not add a one-click “bake Magic Mask to cache” feature for final renders, so manual exporting is the surefire way to never retrack the mask.
- **External matte linking UI:** The method of adding an external matte via the Media Pool (Clip Attributes or dragging into node graph) has been present in Resolve for years, but Resolve 20's interface might be more streamlined. For example, in newer versions you can drag-and-drop a media pool clip into the Color node graph directly to add it as a matte ¹² (in older versions you *had* to use the Add Matte command or link via media pool). Also, as of Resolve 18.5, any external matte node you add is automatically labeled with the filename ¹³, which helps keep track of multiple mattes. These small changes make the external matte workflow easier than it was in, say, Resolve 17.
- **Clip Attributes – Mattes tab:** This is a robust way to assign mattes that existed in Resolve 17/18, but many users only discovered it in later versions. In Resolve 20, using Clip Attributes to add a matte is straightforward and ensures the matte is attached to the source clip across all timelines. In older workflows, people sometimes manually synced mattes using timeline tracks or struggled with offset adjustments – the Clip Attributes method spares those extra steps by using timecode for alignment ⁹. If you tried an external matte in Resolve 17 and found it tedious, revisit it in Resolve 20 with this method for a smoother experience.
- **No Magic Mask needed in node tree:** Once you've replaced a Magic Mask node with an external matte, you can delete or disable the Magic Mask node entirely. In Resolve 20, a project might get heavy with many Magic Mask nodes (especially since Magic Mask 2 invites more usage). Converting them to external mattes and removing the Magic Mask nodes will lighten the project. As one guide puts it: you'll end up with “*no Magic Mask node anywhere, [the] matte is a permanent video file,*” giving you **full flexibility** to grade without the performance hit ¹⁷. This approach in Resolve 20 is essentially the same idea as in 17, but now even more beneficial if you're taking advantage of the improved mask accuracy and want to lock it in.
- **Other new features:** Resolve 20 didn't drastically change how nodes and mattes behave in the Color page, so your node tree logic (serial vs layer mixer) is the same. One thing to note: if you use the new Magic Mask 2 in Color and plan to export the matte, you might find it tracks better/faster, but you still have to manually pipe the mask to output as described. There's no “export mask” button – you still rely on rendering the matte out as a clip. Future versions might integrate Magic Mask caching, but for now, this external matte workflow is the way to go for complex grades.

Troubleshooting Tips for Matte Usage

Working with external mattes is powerful, but you may encounter some quirks. Here are common issues and their solutions:

- **Matte Timing / Alignment Issues:** If the color correction is spilling outside the intended area or lagging behind/ahead, the matte clip might be out of sync with the footage. This often happens if the matte's timecode or starting frame doesn't match the source. Remember, Resolve aligns external mattes by timecode and frame count ¹⁸. For example, if your source clip starts at timecode 01:00:00:00 but your matte starts at 00:00:00:00, an offset will occur (your matte might appear shifted by a fixed number of frames) ¹⁹ ²⁰. To fix this:
- **Use Clip Attributes (Mattes tab):** This usually handles the alignment automatically *if* the matte was generated from the same source range. Resolve will map the matte's frames to the source clip's frames by timecode. So first verify in the Media Pool that the matte is indeed attached to the correct source clip (and not, say, left as an unlinked matte on another clip).
- **Adjust timecode to match:** If you find the matte still misaligns, check the matte file's start timecode. You can do this by right-clicking the matte in the Media Pool > Clip Attributes > General. If it differs from the source clip's start TC, you can manually set it to match. For example, if the matte actually corresponds to a segment starting 1 minute into the source, set the matte's timecode to that of the source clip's 1-minute mark ¹⁸ ¹². This way, frame 1 of the matte will align with the correct frame of the source.
- **Use the Offset slider:** DaVinci Resolve allows slipping an external matte's timing via an offset control. If the matte is added as a node (Node M), click that matte node and look in the **Key tab** or **Node settings** – there is an “**External Matte Offset**” parameter (in frames). You can nudge this value positive or negative to slide the matte in time ²¹. For instance, if the matte is appearing 5 frames too early, offset it +5 frames. The slider can be clunky (range ±10000 frames) so it may take a moment to dial in. This is a last resort if adjusting timecode isn't feasible.
- **Re-export or use handles:** If alignment is consistently problematic (especially if you needed handles for a transition), consider re-exporting the matte with proper handles or as part of the full-length clip. Having extra frames can help if you need to slip the matte a bit. Ultimately, the goal is **frame-perfect sync** – once achieved, the matte will stay locked in place throughout.
- **Resolution or Aspect Ratio Mismatch:** If your matte clip's resolution doesn't match the original footage, the mask might appear scaled or shifted. For example, if you exported a quarter-resolution matte to save time, when applied it might only cover part of the frame or be fuzzy. The best solution is to **export the matte at full resolution** of your timeline or source. However, if you must use a different resolution matte:
- Check the **Scaling settings:** In Project Settings or Clip Attributes, determine how Resolve is scaling the external matte. Resolve will typically scale the matte to fill the frame if the aspect ratio differs, but if the aspect is same and only resolution is smaller, it might scale up (introducing softness). You can right-click the matte clip > **Clip Attributes > Image Scaling** (or use the Inspector in Edit) to adjust scaling behavior (e.g., “Scale entire image to fit” vs “Center crop with no resizing”). Choose a setting that aligns the matte correctly over the subject.
- If minor adjustments are needed, you can also use a **Sizing** adjustment in the Color node: selecting the external matte node and tweaking its tilt/pan/zoom in the Sizing tab could align a mis-positioned

matte. This is rarely needed if resolution and AR match, but it's an option if you find a slight offset due to resolution differences.

- Ultimately, any resolution mismatch can degrade the matte quality. You might see the mask edges not perfectly matching the 4K footage if the matte was HD, for example. For critical work, re-render the matte at the proper resolution.
- **Improper Alpha Blending or Matte Behavior:** If the result looks wrong (e.g., the subject looks transparent, or you see a halo/edge issues, or the correction is partially applied where it shouldn't be), consider these sub-issues:
 - **Matte inversion:** Double-check if you accidentally inverted (or failed to invert) the matte on a node. A common mistake is to apply the matte on two nodes but forget to invert one, resulting in overlapping corrections or missed areas. For instance, if both a subject node and background node use the matte *without inversion*, the background node might also affect the subject (since it's not truly restricted). Ensure one of them is inverted if you intend to split subject vs background ¹⁵.
 - **Layer mixer ordering:** If using a layer mixer, if the foreground/background order is swapped, you might see an unexpected blend (like the background grade overlaying the subject). Make sure the subject branch is the one providing the alpha (usually the top layer). If you see *both* layers' effects globally, it means the matte's alpha isn't being used to composite – likely the connections are wrong. Reconnect the nodes in the proper order or use the node context menu on the mixer to switch inputs.
 - **Alpha mode (premultiplied vs straight):** If your matte clip has an actual alpha channel (e.g., you exported a ProRes 4444 with alpha), Resolve might need to know how to interpret it. A telltale sign is jagged or dark fringes on edges. In the Media Pool, right-click the matte file > Clip Attributes > Alpha Mode. Try switching between **Premultiplied** and **Straight (Unmatted)** to see which looks correct ²². For white-on-black mattes that are not in the alpha channel (just luma), this setting isn't directly relevant – but if you ever import an RGBA file as matte, it's crucial. Generally, if you rendered white on black, you'll use it as luma; if you rendered an actual alpha, set it as straight alpha (unless it was premultiplied on black by the source application).
 - **Matte not fully opaque or holes in mask:** If your white areas aren't pure white, the node's effect will be partially applied. For example, a 90% gray mask area means 90% of the correction is applied there. If you notice the correction isn't as strong as expected on the edges, it could be intentional feathering from Magic Mask. You can tighten the matte by using the **Matte Finesse** controls in the Key panel. Increase **Key Output Gain** to 1.0 if it's lower, which ensures full strength ²³. You can also adjust **Clip Black/White** or **In/Out ratio** sliders to expand the white areas or choke the mask as needed (similar to choking a key). A small **blur radius** can help if edges are too sharp or aliased, and a negative **In** offset can erode the matte to eliminate fringes. These are the same techniques you'd use with qualifiers and can be applied to the external matte key.
- **Color artifacts on edges:** Sometimes you might see a slight halo of the original color around the subject if, say, you heavily grade the background differently. This is often due to the matte edge not being perfectly tight (color from background bleeding onto subject edges). Solution: slightly **expand the subject matte** (increase "Out" or decrease "In" in the Key tab) so that the matte overlaps a bit more into the background, or add a tiny blur. This will soften or hide any harsh edge. Also, check that your grading on the background isn't causing a spill (for example, a strong blur on background might bleed over a hair's edge if the matte was slightly off). In such cases, refining the matte or using a *garbage matte* (an extra window to mask out problematic areas) can help.

- **Multiple mattes or complex node trees:** If you juggle several external mattes (say one for the person's body, one for their eyes, etc.), keep them organized. Resolve allows multiple mattes per clip (Matte 1, Matte 2, etc.). It might be useful to rename nodes or use compound nodes. A troubleshooting tip: if a matte isn't showing effect, ensure you selected the correct one in the dropdown for that node. Also remember that each node can only use one key input at a time – if you need to *combine* mattes (e.g., intersect two mattes), you would use a Key Mixer node to add/multiply them first, then feed that into the correction node. This is advanced usage but worth noting if you ever find a single matte not sufficient. In Resolve 20, the procedure is the same as in earlier versions: a Key Mixer can take multiple external mattes or qualifiers and you set the combine mode (Add = union, Multiply = intersection, etc.).
- **Matte not updating:** If you replace the matte clip with a new version (perhaps you re-rendered a tweaked matte and relinked it), sometimes Resolve doesn't refresh immediately. Try clearing the cache for that clip or removing and re-adding the matte. In worst cases, close and reopen the project. This is rare, but if you notice the matte in use isn't reflecting the new file, a cache refresh usually fixes it.

By following these guidelines, you should have a smooth experience using your exported Magic Mask matte for targeted color correction. The key is to take advantage of Resolve 20's robust external matte support – it lets you enjoy the precision of Magic Mask *without* the slowdowns. **Your node tree will render much faster** (since it's basically just reading a luma clip ²⁴) and you maintain complete control over separate grading of your subject and background. This technique is especially useful in one-person projects where efficiency is critical and you can't afford to retrack or wait on heavy AI processing for each tweak. Enjoy your color grading with this new matte workflow, and happy rendering!

Sources:

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